

Butorides virescens

Green heron



Length 16–19 in (40–48 cm)
Weight 4–8 oz (125–225 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location North and Central America



A common bird of American wetlands, the green heron is one of the few birds known to use a tool to acquire food: it drops bait—worms, twigs, or stolen bread—into shallow water in order to lure fish. Tropical and subtropical populations are sedentary, but in temperate North America, these herons migrate—overwintering in warmer coastal regions, especially favoring mangrove swamps.

Nycticorax nycticorax

Black-crowned night heron

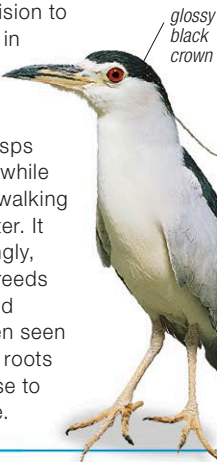


Height 23–25½ in (58–65 cm)
Weight 18–29 oz (500–800 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location North, Central, and South America, Africa, Asia



Unlike most other herons, this small bird feeds at night or at dusk, using its exceptional vision to pinpoint its prey in dim light, and occasionally also responding to sounds. It grasps food with its bill while standing still or walking slowly in the water. It usually feeds singly, but nests and breeds colonially. A good climber, it is often seen clambering over roots or branches close to the water's edge.



Botaurus lentiginosus

American bittern



Height 23½–34 in (60–85 cm)
Weight 18–32 oz (500–900 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location North and Central America, Caribbean



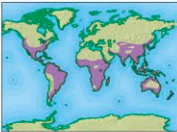
With its streaked and mottled brown plumage, the American bittern is superbly camouflaged for life in dense reedbeds and overgrown marshes. This daytime feeder preys primarily on fish and frogs, stabbing with a lightning-fast lunge of its daggerlike bill. Like other bitterns, when disturbed it assumes a peculiar defensive posture, with its bill upturned and its neck extended, and may sway in the wind with the surrounding grass in order to remain inconspicuous. This bird is widespread across North America, but northern populations—such

as in Canada—migrate southward to overwinter in southern USA and the Caribbean. Its nest is a well-concealed platform of vegetation placed in rushes just above the water level or on solid ground.



Ardea alba

Great egret



Length 34–39 in (85–100 cm)
Weight 34–36 oz (950–1,000 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location North, Central, and South America, Africa, Asia, Australia



The most widespread of all herons, the great egret is found in all kinds of wetlands from the Americas to Asia and Australia. Its plumage is entirely white, and its legs and feet are black.

In the breeding season, long plumes develop on the back, trailing over the relatively short tail. These egrets stalk their prey alone or in loose groups, but within groups individuals defend small territories. Their young in the nest are extremely aggressive, often resulting in the death of weaker chicks.



Bubulcus ibis

Western cattle egret



Height 35–38 in (88–96 cm)
Weight 12–18 oz (300–500 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location Africa, Asia, Europe



Western cattle egrets spread from the Old World to the New World, reaching South America in 1877, North America in 1941, and settling to breed in Florida by 1953. Early arrivals were windblown strays, but the species spread widely through the Americas and, from the 1940s, southeastward to Australia. Flocks are familiar in African savannas, associating with herds of large mammals,

and in the fields and marshes of Iberia. They feed on amphibians, insects, and earthworms, foraging more successfully around large herbivores, including cattle, or even farm machinery, than elsewhere. They breed, often alongside other herons and egrets, in treetop colonies.



Threskiornis aethiopicus

African sacred ibis



Length 26–35 in (65–89 cm)
Weight 3¼ lb (1.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location Africa (south of Sahara), Madagascar, Aldabra Island, W. Asia



This medium-sized white ibis, with its strikingly black, featherless head and upper neck, was revered in ancient Egypt. A generalized feeder, it easily cohabits with people and consumes a variety of foods—refuse and offal around human

habitations, insects in grassland areas, and aquatic animals in shallow pools.



Geronticus eremita

Northern bald ibis



Length 32 in (80 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Critically endangered

Location N.W. Africa, W. Asia



Once widespread throughout southern Europe, North Africa, and West Asia, this ibis is now extremely rare. It has a bare red head, a straggly black crest on the nape of its neck, and brownish black iridescent plumage. It feeds near



pools and dry river beds, using its long, curved bill to probe for insects and other small animals in loose ground. It nests in colonies on steep cliffs, where its young are relatively safe from attack.